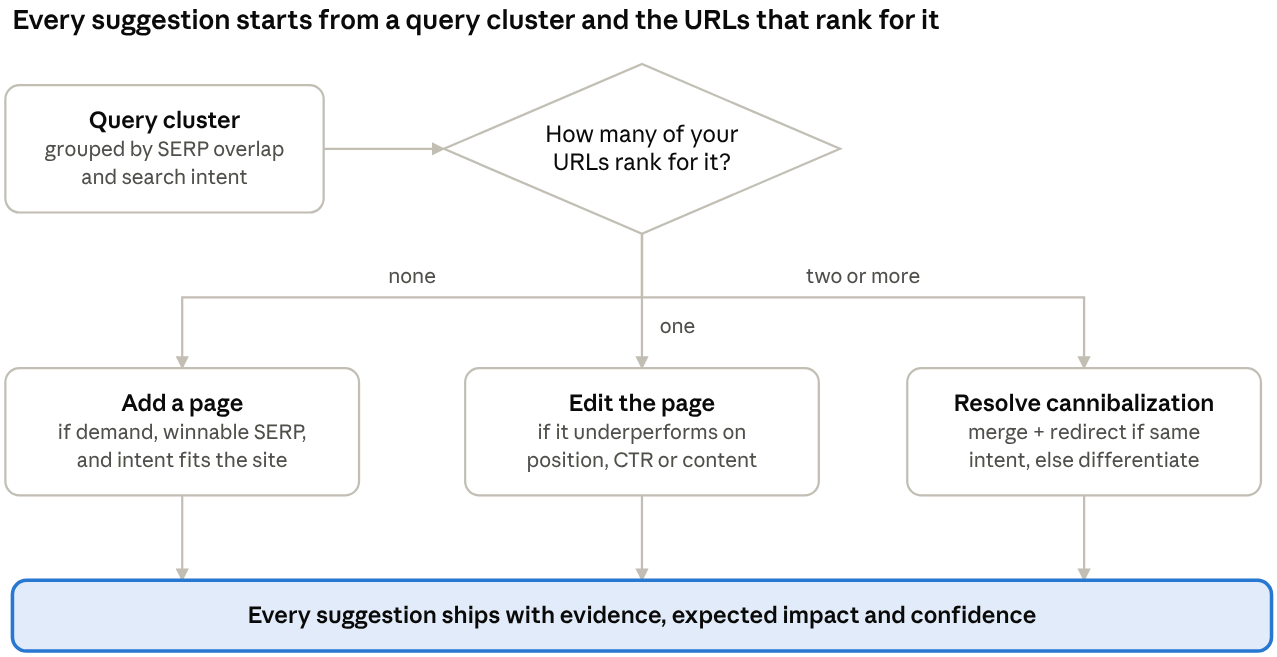
SEO Decision Strategies for an Add/Edit Page Agent

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The decision space

Your agent makes one decision over and over: for a given pocket of search demand, which of your URLs should own it, and what change gets it there. Add, edit and consolidate are three answers to that single question.



core decision · one question, three outcomes

What this means for the product:

- **The unit of analysis is the query cluster, not the keyword or the page.** GSC tells you how your URLs perform on queries; DataForSEO tells you the market around those queries. Both get joined onto clusters.
- **User prompts route to playbooks.** A playbook is a fixed evidence recipe (which data to pull), a decision rule (when to add, edit or consolidate), and an output schema. The LLM routes the prompt, fills parameters and explains; deterministic analyses do the math.

- **Every suggestion carries the same fields:** action type, target URL (or proposed URL + slug), target cluster, the evidence numbers, what to change, expected impact, confidence and effort. That shared schema is what lets your screen-and-review stages work across playbooks, the same way they do in your internal-linking agent.

Data provider 1: Google Search Console

GSC is your only first-party view of how Google treats your pages: which queries each URL gets shown for, and how it performs there. It says nothing about competitors or true search volume.

Source	What you get	Limits that shape the product	Decisions it feeds
Search Analytics API	Clicks, impressions, CTR, avg. position by query, page, country, device, date; search types web, image, video, news, Discover	Returns top rows, not all; max 50K rows per day per search type; 25K rows per request; some rows dropped when you group by page or query; data lands 2–3 days late (limits)	Striking distance, CTR gaps, decay, query-to-page mapping, cannibalization
searchAppearance dimension	Performance split by result type (rich results, video, etc.)	Can't be combined with other dimensions; needs a two-step query	SERP-feature gaps on your own pages
Bulk export to BigQuery	Every raw row daily, no row cap, history beyond 16 months	Only from the day you enable it; anonymized query text still excluded	Long-tail analysis, big sites, reliable trends
URL Inspection API	Index status, Google-selected vs declared canonical, last crawl	Per-URL calls with a daily quota (roughly 2,000 per property, from memory)	Explains "page exists but gets nothing"; canonical conflicts

Source	What you get	Limits that shape the product	Decisions it feeds
Sitemaps API	Submitted sitemaps and their status	—	Inventory sanity checks
UI-only reports	Branded query filter (all sites since April 2026); Generative AI performance report (AI Overviews, AI Mode; launched June 3, 2026)	Neither the API nor bulk export exposes the AI report as of August 2026	Manual CSV upload if you want AI visibility per page

Three properties of GSC data your analyses must respect:

- **Anonymized queries are a big blind spot.** One practitioner measured 57.7% of impressions in the anonymized pool on his own site in August 2026, and AI Mode queries are almost all anonymized. Page-level totals are reliable; query-level coverage is partial.
- **Position is an impression-weighted average.** A page at "8.4" may be #3 on one query and #40 on another, so compute at query × page level, never page level alone.
- **GSC shows only demand you already touch.** A query you have zero impressions for never appears, which is why add-page decisions need DataForSEO.

Data provider 2: DataForSEO

DataForSEO supplies the market side GSC lacks: search volume, difficulty, intent, live SERPs, competitors' rankings and pages, backlinks, and AI-answer visibility. For an add/edit agent, five of its API families matter most; the rest are niche. Endpoint names below come from the v3 docs index.

API family	Endpoints that matter for you	Question it answers	Feeds
SERP API	Google Organic (Live/Task, Advanced), AI Mode, Autocomplete; also Bing, YouTube	Who ranks now, with which page type, and which SERP features (snippet, PAA, AI Overview, video, local) take the space	Intent classification, SERP-overlap clustering, content-format decision, feature targeting
DataForSEO Labs – keyword research	Keyword Overview, Keyword Ideas, Keyword Suggestions, Related Keywords, Bulk Keyword Difficulty, Search Intent, Historical Keyword Data, Keywords For Site	How big, how hard, what intent, and is demand rising or seasonal	Sizing opportunities, prioritization, cluster expansion
DataForSEO Labs – competitor research	Ranked Keywords, SERP Competitors, Competitors Domain, Domain Intersection, Page Intersection, Relevant Pages, Historical SERPs, Bulk Traffic Estimation	Which keywords and pages competitors win that you don't; who your real SERP competitors are per topic	Keyword gap, content gap, add-page candidates, SERP volatility
Keywords Data API	Google Ads Search Volume, Keywords For Keywords, Google Trends Explore, Clickstream search volume	Volume from Ads or clickstream; trend curves	Cross-checking Labs volumes, seasonality timing for refreshes

API family	Endpoints that matter for you	Question it answers	Feeds
OnPage API	Content Parsing (Live), Instant Pages, Pages, Duplicate Content, Duplicate Tags, Microdata, Links, Non-Indexable	The structure and text of any page — yours or a competitor's — headings, word count, schema, links	Competitor content benchmarking, section-gap analysis, technical blockers
Backlinks API	Summary, Referring Domains, Bulk Ranks, Page Intersection, Domain Pages	How much link authority a ranking page or domain has	"Is this SERP winnable?", which of two cannibalizing URLs to keep
AI Optimization API	LLM Mentions (Search Mentions, Top Mentioned Pages/Domains), AI Keyword Data search volume, LLM Responses and Scrapers for ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Perplexity	Whether your brand and pages are cited in AI answers, and who is cited instead	AI-visibility edits (answer-first sections, citable facts)
Content Analysis API	Search, Summary, Sentiment, Phrase Trends	How a topic or brand is discussed across the web	Topic freshness and angle ideas (secondary)

Two product notes. First, Labs data is a pre-built database (fast, cheap, slightly stale), while the SERP API is a live scrape (fresh, costlier) — use Labs for breadth and the SERP API only on the shortlist you will recommend on. Second, results are stored 30 days for Standard tasks and not at all for Live calls, so cache SERP snapshots yourself; you will want them later to measure whether a suggestion worked.

Other data worth adding

The biggest gap after GSC and DataForSEO is knowledge of your own content and its business value; you already have most of it from the internal-linking agent.

Source	What it adds	Why the agent needs it
Your crawl + page store	URL inventory, title, H1–H3 outline, body text, schema, word count, publish and last-modified dates, indexability	Every edit suggestion is a diff against the current page; every add suggestion must prove no existing page covers it
Page embeddings	Vector per page and per section	Topic map of the site; semantic duplicate detection; "does any page already cover this cluster?"
Internal-link graph + your authority score	Inbound links, depth, the authority you already compute	Which page to keep in a merge; whether a new page can get link support; hand-off to your linking agent
GA4	Sessions, engagement, conversions and revenue per landing page	Weights opportunities by business value, not traffic; stops the agent from "fixing" a page that converts well
Business context (user-supplied)	Products, ICP, priority categories, brand terms, pages that must not change	Filters out on-topic but useless keywords; makes brand vs non-brand explicit
Bing Webmaster Tools	Query and page data for Bing	Second opinion on queries GSC anonymizes; Bing also feeds Copilot answers
PageSpeed / CrUX	Core Web Vitals per URL or origin	Rarely the reason a page loses, but a necessary tie-breaker in edit diagnosis
Change log	What was edited, when, and why	Lets you measure whether past suggestions worked and avoid re-suggesting the same edit

Ahrefs, Semrush or Similarweb APIs can replace parts of DataForSEO, but they overlap heavily; one market-data provider is enough.

Strategy family 1: edit-page decisions

Edit suggestions come from comparing a page against three benchmarks: its own past (decay), the CTR its position should earn, and the pages that outrank it. Practitioners agree edits to pages that already rank are usually the cheapest wins, so this family should be your default when a prompt is vague.

Strategy	Trigger in the data	Data needed	What the suggestion changes
Striking distance	Query × page at avg. position roughly 4–20 with meaningful impressions and a relevant page. No official range exists; teams use 4–15, 5–20 or 8–20 as a starting filter	GSC query × page; top-10 SERP; competitor page outlines	Add or deepen the section that answers that query, align headings, pass internal links (hand-off to your linking agent)
CTR gap	CTR well below what the page's position should earn. Build the expected-CTR curve from your own GSC data per position bucket, split brand/non-brand and by SERP features present	GSC; SERP Advanced for features above you	Rewrite title and meta description; add structured data for an eligible rich result
Content decay	Clicks down more than about 20% vs. a comparable period, or three consecutive months of falling impressions, with no seasonal explanation	GSC time series; Historical Keyword Data or Trends for seasonality; Historical SERPs	Depends on the cause — see the table below

Strategy	Trigger in the data	Data needed	What the suggestion changes
Intent / format mismatch	Your page type differs from the dominant type in the top 10 (guide vs. listicle vs. product vs. tool)	SERP API + page-type classifier	Restructure to the winning format; if the gap is fundamental, suggest a new page instead
Competitor content gap	Subtopics, entities or questions that most top-10 pages cover and yours lacks	OnPage Content Parsing on top 10; People Also Ask; Related Keywords	Specific sections, FAQs, tables or examples to add
Query drift	Page earns impressions for queries it never explicitly addresses (long tail in GSC)	GSC query × page; page text	Add sections for the drift queries, or retitle to the broader head term they share
SERP feature capture	Featured snippet, PAA or video present; you rank top 5 but don't hold it	SERP Advanced; your page structure	Answer-first paragraph, list or table formatting, schema
Freshness	Top results are recently dated; your page has stale years, stats or product names	SERP (dates); page text; CMS last-modified	Update facts and dates, and state what changed

Decay is a symptom, so the agent must diagnose before it suggests. The pattern of change across GSC metrics points to the cause:

Pattern	Likely cause	Suggested action
Position falls, impressions fall	Competitors improved or a new page type now wins	Competitor gap + intent check, then content edit
Position steady, impressions fall	Market demand fell (check volume trend)	Usually no edit; retarget if demand moved to a new phrasing

Pattern	Likely cause	Suggested action
Position steady, CTR falls	A SERP feature or AI Overview now sits above you	Snippet rewrite, feature capture, or AI-citation edits
Clicks move to another of your URLs	Cannibalization	Hand to strategy family 3
Page disappears entirely	Indexing or canonical problem	Flag as technical via URL Inspection; not a content edit

One guardrail: check GA4 conversions before suggesting heavy edits on a page that already converts well; a rewrite for traffic can cost revenue.

Strategy family 2: add-page decisions

An add suggestion is justified only when four things are true: there is demand, no existing page of yours owns it, the SERP wants a page you don't have, and the SERP is winnable for your site. Most tools fail on the second test and create cannibalization, so make it the hardest gate.

Where add candidates come from:

Strategy	How candidates are found	Data needed
Competitor keyword gap	Keywords where two or more of your real SERP competitors rank top 10 and you don't rank or rank past ~50	Labs SERP Competitors, Domain Intersection, Ranked Keywords
Competitor page gap	Competitor URLs earning traffic on topics you have no page for	Labs Relevant Pages, Page Intersection
Topical map coverage	Build the full keyword universe for your core topics, cluster it, map clusters to your pages; unmapped clusters are gaps	Keyword Ideas, Keywords For Categories, SERP API, your embeddings
Hub completion	A pillar page exists but subtopic spokes that competitors have are missing	Your site structure + competitor site sections

Strategy	How candidates are found	Data needed
GSC-born demand	Queries with real impressions where your best URL ranks poorly (past ~20) and only mentions the topic in passing	GSC query × page; page text
Format split	The SERP wants a different page type than any you have (comparison, "best X", alternatives, calculator, template)	SERP page-type classification
Emerging demand	Queries with rising volume in your niche before competitors cover them	Historical Keyword Data, Trends, Top Searches
Templated patterns	Many keywords sharing a modifier ("X integration", "X in [city]", "X alternatives")	Keyword Ideas + pattern mining

The edit-vs-add test. Before any add, compare the candidate's top-10 SERP with the SERPs of your nearest existing page's main queries. A widely used rule treats 3–4 shared URLs in the top 10 (about 40% overlap) as the same intent, meaning edit the existing page. One open-source tool uses finer review bands: 7–10 shared URLs means review for merge, 4–6 means same cluster, 2–3 is weak. Pair this with embedding similarity between the candidate cluster and your page; SERP overlap decides page mapping, and embeddings find which page to compare against.

The winnability gate. Compare the top 10 with your own site: keyword difficulty, referring domains and rank of the ranking pages and domains, and whether weaker results (forums, thin pages, small sites) appear. A cluster where every result is a high-authority domain is a poor add for a small site even with high volume.

The business-fit gate. Relevance to what you sell, and GA4 value of similar existing pages. User-supplied context (products, ICP, priority categories) is what makes this possible.

A good add suggestion is a brief, not an idea: proposed title and slug, primary and secondary keywords, intent and format, an outline derived from what the top 10 cover plus what they miss, the parent hub and internal links it should receive, and the evidence behind each gate.

Strategy family 3: cannibalization

Two URLs appearing for one query is not cannibalization by itself; it is cannibalization when they serve the same intent and split visibility so neither wins. The agent needs a severity score to avoid false positives, then two separate decisions: which URL owns the cluster, and what happens to the others.

Detection signals (all from GSC query × page, over two or more date ranges):

- Two or more URLs with a meaningful share of impressions for the same query or cluster, and no single URL concentrating them.
- URLs swapping positions over time, with a small position gap between them.
- A concentration score of click share per query; some tools use the Herfindahl-Hirschman Index to grade how split clicks are.
- Cluster-level check: the pages' own main queries have high SERP overlap with each other (the same test as edit-vs-add).

Exclude as false positives: branded queries, pages that serve genuinely different intents Google ranks side by side, a stable pair where one URL clearly dominates, and queries with too few impressions to matter.

Choosing the owner URL — score candidates on non-brand clicks and position for the cluster, backlinks and referring domains (Backlinks API), your internal authority score, GA4 conversions, and how closely the page's format matches the SERP's winning type. Branded clicks can inflate a page's apparent strength, so weigh non-brand data.

Choosing the action for the others:

Situation	Action	What the suggestion must include
Same intent; loser has some unique useful content	Merge into owner, 301 redirect	Sections to move, redirect map, internal links to repoint, sitemap removal
Same intent; loser has nothing unique, but has links or traffic	301 redirect only	Redirect map, link updates
Different intents that overlap on surface keywords	Differentiate: retarget each page to its own intent	New title, H1 and focus per page; cross-links between them

Situation	Action	What the suggestion must include
Loser has value for other queries but competes on this one	De-optimize: remove the competing section or targeting	Text to cut or reframe; link to owner
Near-duplicates both needed for users (variants, filters)	Canonical to owner	Canonical target
Thin, no traffic, no links, nothing to keep	Delete (410) or noindex	Evidence of zero value, links to remove

One caution for the reviewer stage: consolidation outcomes are published mostly as success stories (one widely cited case reported a 466% click increase), so treat claimed uplift as a hypothesis and measure it.

Cross-cutting analyses every playbook reuses

These six analyses are shared building blocks; build each once as a tool and let every playbook call it. They are where the SERP, competitor and keyword data actually get turned into judgment.

Analysis	What it outputs	Built from	Used by
SERP anatomy	Page type of each top-10 result (guide, listicle, product, category, tool, forum, video), dominant type, SERP features present, AI Overview present and who it cites	SERP API Advanced + a page-type classifier	Intent mismatch, format split, CTR model, feature capture
Intent label	Informational / commercial / transactional / navigational per keyword and cluster	Labs Search Intent, checked against SERP anatomy	Clustering, owner choice, business fit

Analysis	What it outputs	Built from	Used by
Clustering	Keyword groups by SERP overlap, with embedding similarity as a first pass	SERP API snapshots, embeddings	Everything: the unit of analysis
Cluster-to-URL map	Which of your pages owns, partly covers, or competes for each cluster	GSC query × page, page embeddings, overlap test	Add vs. edit vs. cannibalization routing
Competitor benchmark	Per cluster: topics and questions most top pages cover (consensus), what only one or two cover (differentiators), typical length, media, schema, freshness	OnPage Content Parsing on the top 3–10, PAA	Edit gaps, add-page outlines
Opportunity model	Expected extra clicks if the page reaches a target position, and the confidence of that estimate	Volume, current position, your own CTR curve, SERP features	Prioritization of every suggestion

Adjust the opportunity model for AI Overviews, or it will overpromise. Ahrefs found an AI Overview correlated with a 58% lower CTR for the top-ranking page as of December 2025. Seer Interactive's tracking shows the trend is not fixed: CTR on AI Overview queries rose from 1.3% in December 2025 to 2.4% in February 2026, and being cited in the overview delivered 2–5x the CTR of not being cited. Practical rule: calibrate CTR from your own GSC data split by "AI Overview present / absent", and refresh it quarterly.

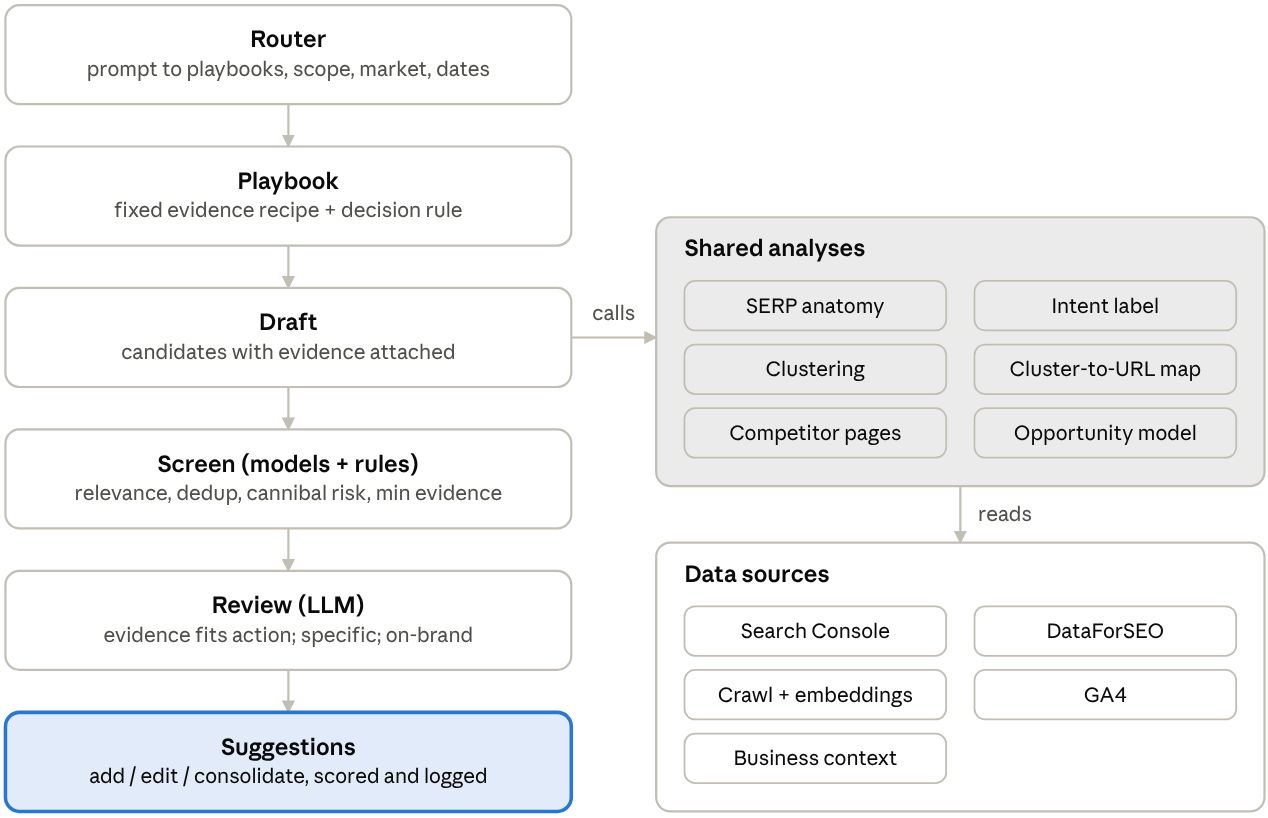
Treat AI citation as its own goal. For informational clusters where an AI Overview appears, the edit that matters may be earning a citation rather than a rank: a direct answer near the top, specific facts and figures, clean tables. DataForSEO's AI Mode SERP and LLM Mentions endpoints tell you whether you are cited and who is instead.

Watch SERP volatility. Historical SERPs show whether a cluster's top 10 churns (room to enter) or has held the same winners for a year (hard to break). Feed this into confidence, not just priority.

What to implement

Implement a router, about nine playbooks, the six shared analyses, and your existing draft → screen → review → write pipeline on top. The playbooks are the product; the analyses are the engine they share.

Playbooks draft from shared analyses; screen and review gate every suggestion



capability map · router, playbooks, shared analyses, gates

The router turns a free-form prompt into one or more playbooks plus scope (whole site, a folder, one URL, one keyword), market and date range, and asks only when scope is truly ambiguous.

Playbook catalog

Playbook	Typical prompts	Evidence recipe	Can output
Quick wins	"What should I optimize this month?"	Striking distance + CTR gap across the site, sized by opportunity model	Edit
Traffic drop	"Why did /pricing lose traffic?"	Decay diagnosis table, SERP now vs. then, competitor changes	Edit, consolidate, technical flag
Page audit	"Improve this page" / "Rank this page for X"	Page's GSC queries, SERP anatomy and competitor benchmark for its main cluster	Edit (or add if the target needs a different page)
Content gaps	"What should we write next?"	Topical map + competitor keyword and page gaps, through the edit-vs-add test and the gates	Add, some edit
Competitor	"How do we beat competitor.com?"	Domain Intersection, Relevant Pages, per-cluster benchmark	Add, edit
Cannibalization	"Are my pages competing?"	Query × page split scoring, owner choice	Consolidate, differentiate, delete
Topic cluster	"Build out our X topic"	Cluster map for one topic: owned, weak, missing	Add, edit, consolidate
AI visibility	"Why aren't we in AI Overviews?"	AI Overview presence and citations, LLM Mentions	Edit

Playbook	Typical prompts	Evidence recipe	Can output
Refresh plan	"What should we update before Q4?"	Decay + seasonality from Trends and historical volume	Edit, ordered by date

Gates for your screen stage

- **Relevance:** the cluster matters to the business (from user-supplied context and GA4 value of similar pages).
- **Evidence floor:** minimum impressions or volume and data window before a suggestion can exist; lower confidence when the anonymized share is high.
- **Duplication:** an add suggestion must fail the overlap and embedding test against every existing page.
- **Conflict:** no two suggestions target the same cluster with different URLs; an add and an edit on one cluster get merged or one is dropped.
- **Protected pages:** pages the user marked off-limits, or pages converting well, only get light edits.

What the LLM reviewer checks

That the action follows from the numbers cited, that the change is specific (named sections, titles, redirects — not "improve content"), that it matches the SERP's winning format, and that the expected impact is stated with its assumptions.

Prioritization and learning

- **Score** each suggestion as expected click gain × page value × confidence, divided by effort. Confidence drops with thin data, SERP volatility, AI Overview presence and high anonymized share.
- **Log** every suggestion with its evidence snapshot (GSC numbers and the SERP you saw).
- **Measure** outcomes in GSC at 4, 8 and 12 weeks for suggestions the user implemented, and use the results to re-tune thresholds (position bands, overlap cut-offs, CTR curve). This loop is what turns the SERP overlap numbers and position ranges above from conventions into rules fitted to your users' sites.

Build order

1. Cluster-to-URL map and SERP anatomy — every playbook depends on them.
2. Quick wins, page audit, cannibalization — GSC-heavy, cheapest data, clearest wins.
3. Content gaps, competitor, topic cluster — need DataForSEO Labs and the add-page gates.
4. Traffic drop, refresh plan, AI visibility — need history and the outcome log.

Sources

Thresholds quoted from practitioners (position bands, overlap cut-offs, decay rules) are conventions, not Google rules; the outcome log is how you replace them with your own.

- Search Analytics: query — Search Console API
- Getting your performance data — Search Console API
- Search Console BigQuery export: what it costs
- New Google Search Console features, 2026
- How to track Google AI Mode traffic in Search Console — Suganthan
- DataForSEO API v3 documentation
- Striking distance keywords — CiteWins
- SEO content prioritization framework — Spike
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- AIO impact on Google CTR, 2026 update — Seer Interactive